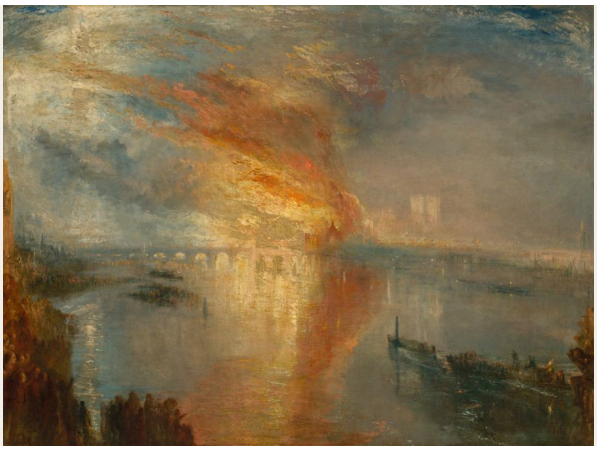
CLEVELAND, UNITED STATES

Cleveland Museum of Art: Masterpieces

Twenty works seen from a riverbank, a doorway, a boxing crowd and other revealing positions.



Turner's burning Parliament can be watched from a safe distance, across the Thames. Caravaggio allows much less room around a dying saint. In Monet's *The Red Kerchief*, the glass doors remain between the viewer and Camille, outside in the snow. These are choices about access: how close a painting lets someone come, and what it places in the way.

That question connects this selection from the Cleveland Museum of Art without making the works tell a single story. Some offer an expansive survey; others narrow the field to a face, a body or a flower. Notice the implied position of the observer before deciding what the scene means. Sometimes the most consequential detail is the place left for you outside it.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/cleveland-museum-art

The selection · 20

1. The Burning of the Houses of Lords and Commons
   J. M. W. Turner · 1835
2. The Red Kerchief
   Claude Monet · c. 1868–73
3. The Crucifixion of Saint Andrew
   Caravaggio · 1606–7
4. The Holy Family with Saints John and Margaret
   Filippino Lippi · c. 1488–93
5. The Large Plane Trees
   Vincent van Gogh · 1889
6. Lot and His Daughters
   Antoine Pesne · 1756
7. The Dream
   Salvador Dalí · 1931
8. The Power of Music
   William Sidney Mount · 1847
9. The Brook
   Paul Cézanne · c. 1895–1900
10. The Crucifixion
    Matteo di Giovanni · 1470s
11. Twilight in the Wilderness
    Frederic Edwin Church · 1860
12. Stag at Sharkey's
    George Bellows · 1909
13. Christ and the Virgin in the House at Nazareth
    Francisco de Zurbarán · c. 1640
14. Church Street El
    Charles Sheeler · 1920
15. Cupid and Psyche
    Jacques-Louis David · 1817
16. Danaë
    Orazio Gentileschi · c. 1623
17. Elizabeth Shewell West and Her Son Raphael
    Benjamin West · c. 1770
18. Hunting near Hartenfels Castle
    Lucas Cranach the Elder · 1540
19. La Cervara, the Roman Campagna
    Jean-Baptiste-Camille Corot · c. 1830–31
20. Morning Glory with Black
    Georgia O'Keeffe · 1926

01 / 20

The Burning of the Houses of Lords and Commons

J. M. W. Turner

1835 · Oil on canvas · Cleveland Museum of Art



Bequest of John L. Severance. Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The river carries the fire's reflection towards the watching crowd. Turner painted this version after the destruction of Parliament in October 1834, exaggerating the flames rather than producing a neutral record. The buildings become difficult to distinguish from their own burning. Across the water there is distance enough to watch, but no escape from the orange light.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1942.647

02 / 20

The Red Kerchief

Claude Monet

c. 1868–73 · Oil on fabric · Cleveland Museum of Art



Bequest of Leonard C. Hanna Jr.. The Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · CC0 1.0

Camille Monet looks through the French doors from outside. Her red covering draws attention through the pale curtains and snowy setting, while the panes keep the two spaces apart. A portrait need not give a sitter an unobstructed place before us: here, recognition occurs in passing, through the frame and glass of an ordinary house.

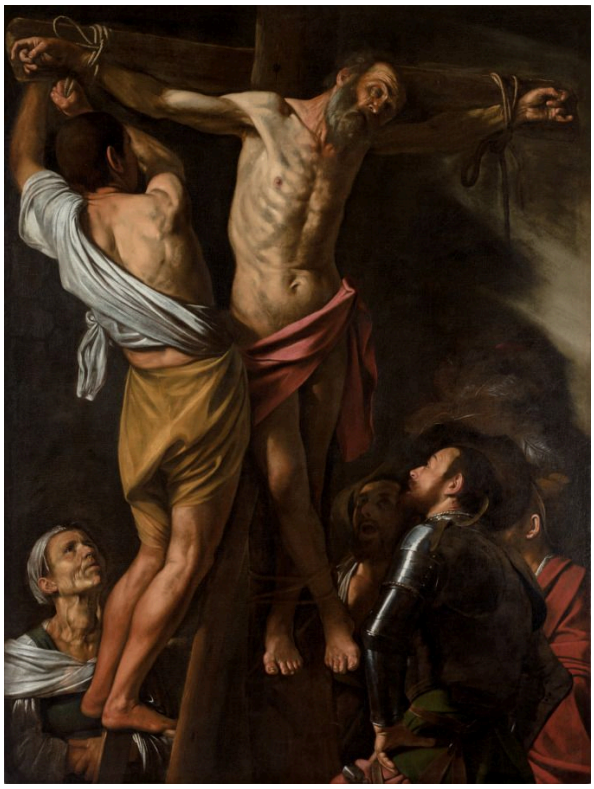
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1958.39

03 / 20

The Crucifixion of Saint Andrew

Caravaggio

1606–7 · Oil on canvas · Cleveland Museum of Art



Leonard C. Hanna Jr. Fund. The Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · CC0 1.0

Caravaggio leaves little space in which to stand back from the martyrdom. Andrew's aging body, the people around him and their rough clothes emerge from a darkness that hides much of the setting. Instead of surveying an entire sacred event, the viewer must attend to its physical business: bodies held up, hands reaching, faces close enough to register suffering.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1976.2

04 / 20

The Holy Family with Saints John and Margaret

Filippino Lippi

c. 1488–93 · Tempera and oil on wood · Cleveland Museum of Art



The Delia E. Holden Fund and a fund donated as a memorial to Mrs. Holden by her children: Guerdon S. Holden, Delia Holden White, Roberta Holden Bole, Emery Holden Greenough, Gertrude Holden McGinley. The Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · CC0 1.0

A round frame gives Filippino Lippi no neutral corners in which to leave spare space. Companions gather around Mary and the infant, their gestures overlapping within the curve. The glimpses of landscape offer relief from this close grouping. Follow the hands and turns of the heads: the company acquires its order through relationships, not simply through symmetry.

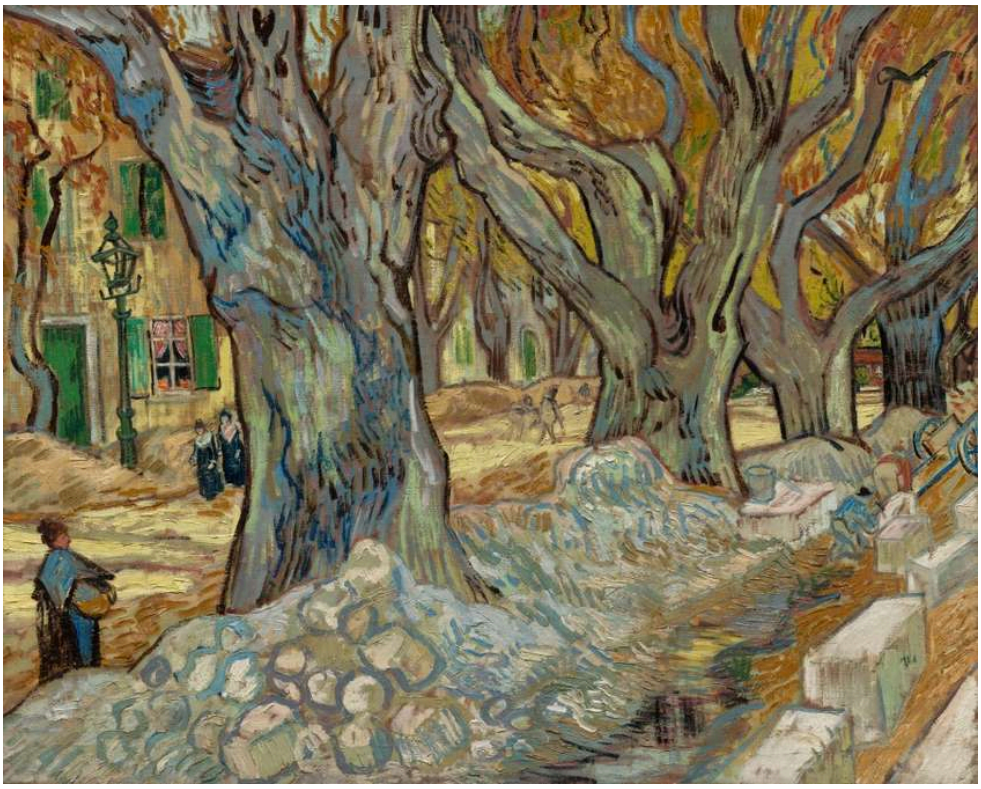
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1932.227

05 / 20

The Large Plane Trees

Vincent van Gogh

1889 · Oil on fabric · Cleveland Museum of Art



Gift of the Hanna Fund. The Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · CC0 1.0

The road workers are small beside the trunks, yet their task keeps this from becoming a view of trees alone. Van Gogh distinguishes paving, bark and foliage through changes in his short strokes. Street repair and seasonal growth occupy the same piece of ground; the painted surface gives as much activity to the trees as to the people working beneath them.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1947.209

06 / 20

Lot and His Daughters

Antoine Pesne

1756 · Black and red chalk wash, gray wash, heightened with white gouache; framing lines in black ink · Cleveland Museum of Art



Antoine Pesne. Lot and His Daughters. The Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

Pesne's drawing concentrates on how three bodies fit together on uneven ground. Warm washes suggest their volume without closing every contour, while darker touches give faces and clothing more weight. The biblical subject supplies a narrative, but the sheet also permits a more practical reading: a group being assembled through adjustments of pose, overlap and emphasis.

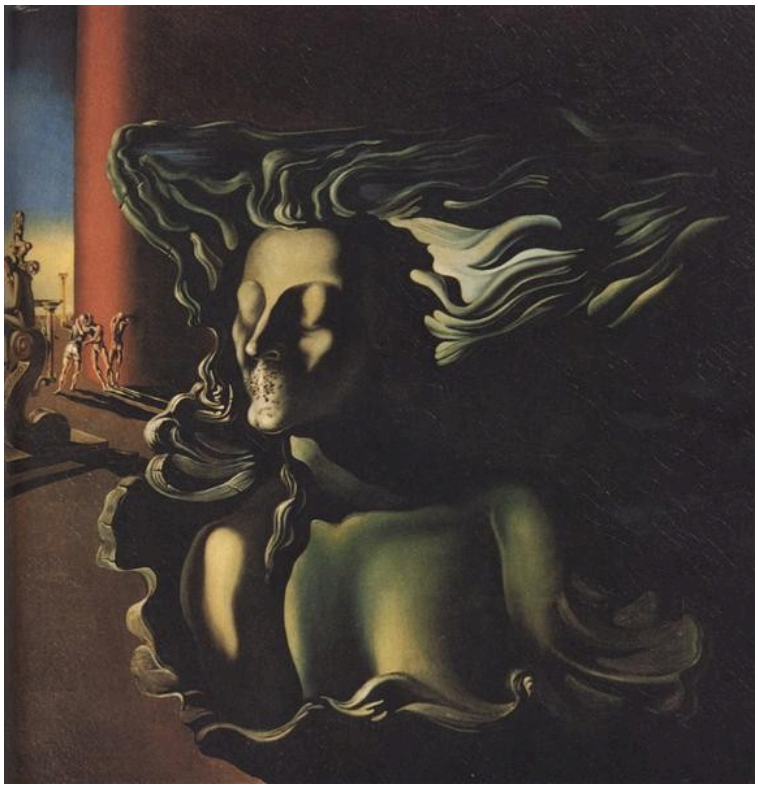
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1975.15

07 / 20

The Dream

Salvador Dalí

1931 · Oil on canvas · Cleveland Museum of Art



Salvador Dalí. The Dream. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

Dalí does not make a dream by leaving everything vague. The head, the distant column and the streaming, hair-like forms have a disconcerting clarity. What becomes unstable is their relationship: scale and substance no longer behave as expected. Naming each component therefore does little to settle the image. Its difficulty lies between the things rather than inside their outlines.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 2001.34

08 / 20

The Power of Music

William Sidney Mount

1847 · Oil on canvas · Cleveland Museum of Art



Leonard C. Hanna Jr. Fund. Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

Music passes through a doorway that the Black listener does not cross. His resting posture connects him to the performance inside, yet the wall keeps his body separate from the musicians. Mount's scene holds pleasure and exclusion together. To describe it only as music bringing people together would overlook the boundary on which the whole composition depends.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1991.110

09 / 20

The Brook

Paul Cézanne

c. 1895–1900 · Oil on fabric · Cleveland Museum of Art



Paul Cézanne. The Brook. The Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

The stream offers a way into Cézanne's wooded scene, though its banks are not drawn as continuous, tidy edges. Blue, green and ochre patches meet, overlap and separate to suggest water and vegetation. Space has to be gathered from these changing relationships. The brook remains recognisable without requiring every stroke to dissolve into a named object.

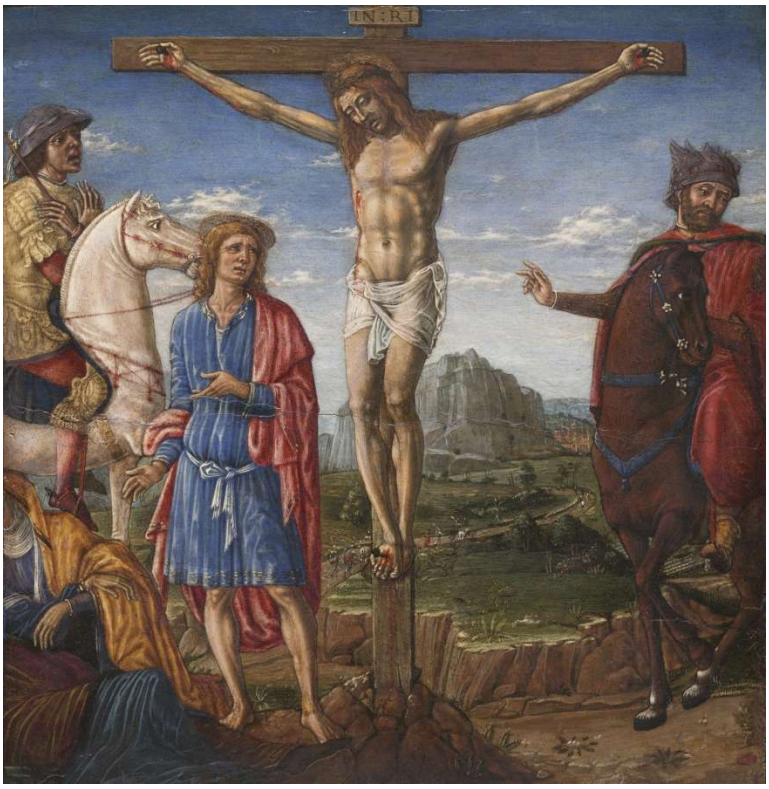
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1958.20

10 / 20

The Crucifixion

Matteo di Giovanni

1470s · Tempera and oil with gold on wood panel · Cleveland Museum of Art



Matteo di Giovanni. The Crucifixion. The Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · CC0 1.0

Matteo di Giovanni gives the witnesses distinct places beneath the tall cross. Firm contours and separate colours make their gestures available for close reading within the small field. Compared with Caravaggio's crowded darkness, this Crucifixion offers a more ordered encounter: the event is severe, but the arrangement allows attention to move deliberately from one participant to another.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1940.535

11 / 20

Twilight in the Wilderness

Frederic Edwin Church

1860 · Oil on canvas · Cleveland Museum of Art



Mr. and Mrs. William H. Marlatt Fund. Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

Church puts the greatest blaze of colour above an unpeopled valley. The dark foreground trees establish a near position from which the water and distant hills can be followed towards the red clouds. Nothing needs to happen on the ground to give the picture drama. A change of light is large enough to organise the whole landscape.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1965.233

12 / 20

Stag at Sharkey's

George Bellows

1909 · Oil on canvas · Cleveland Museum of Art



George Bellows. Stag at Sharkey's. George Bellows; The Cleveland Museum of Art; Hinman B. Hurlbut Collection. CC0 1.0 (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/zero/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

The spectators press up below the ring while the boxers collide above them. Bellows's rough handling keeps arms, faces and bodies from settling into polished separate forms. Watching is part of the picture's action: the crowd's proximity gives the contest its cramped social space. This is a very different spectator's position from the distant riverbank in Turner.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1922.1133

13 / 20

Christ and the Virgin in the House at Nazareth

Francisco de Zurbarán

c. 1640 · Oil on canvas · Cleveland Museum of Art



Leonard C. Hanna Jr. Fund. The Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · CC0 1.0

Zurbarán leaves room between the boy and the woman, making their separate poses noticeable in the sparse household. Small objects, flowers and birds reward a slower inspection than the broad arrangement initially requires. The title identifies a sacred family, but their setting brings attention down to the scale of a table, a task and time spent together indoors.

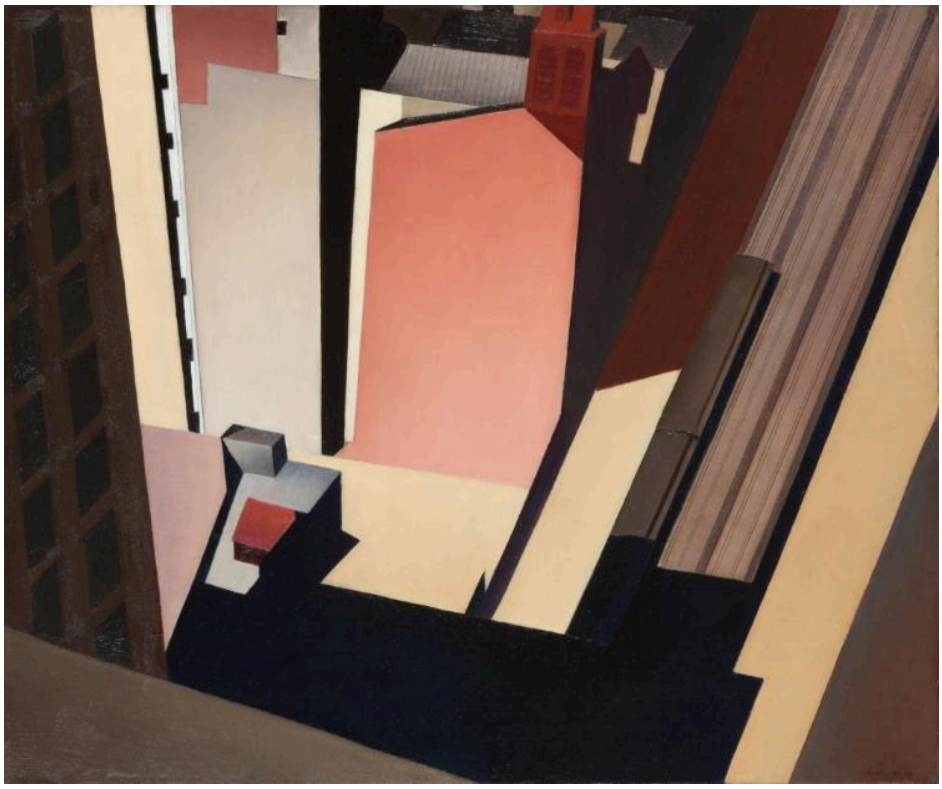
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1960.117

14 / 20

Church Street El

Charles Sheeler

1920 · Oil on canvas · Cleveland Museum of Art



Mr. and Mrs. William H. Marlatt Fund. Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

Seen steeply from above, the elevated railway and buildings become interlocking planes. Sheeler reduces the incidental details that might turn the view into a busy street anecdote. The practical city remains identifiable, but its edges begin to compete with that identity: a track is also a line, and a shadow can be as substantial as the structure casting it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1977.43

15 / 20

Cupid and Psyche

Jacques-Louis David

1817 · Oil on canvas · Cleveland Museum of Art



Leonard C. Hanna Jr. Fund. The Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · CC0 1.0

Cupid turns outwards while Psyche sleeps, making the two figures unequally aware of being seen. David's elaborate bed and opened landscape give the myth a sumptuous setting, but the youth's direct glance unsettles its distance from the viewer. Attention moves from the sleeping body to the person who seems to have caught someone looking at it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1962.37

16 / 20

Danaë

Orazio Gentileschi

c. 1623 · Oil on canvas · Cleveland Museum of Art



Leonard C. Hanna Jr. Fund. The Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · CC0 1.0

The falling gold sets hands and arms in motion above the pale bed. Gentileschi makes a supernatural visitation occur among fabrics whose weight and folds seem insistently tangible. Dark curtains enclose the action, limiting the world to this exchange between the reclining figure and what arrives from above. The myth is explained through reach and response rather than a crowded setting.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1971.101

17 / 20

Elizabeth Shewell West and Her Son Raphael

Benjamin West

c. 1770 · Oil on canvas · Cleveland Museum of Art



The Charles W. Harkness Gift. Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0; compressed study reproduction. · CC0 1.0

Benjamin West brings the child's face close to his mother's cheek and gathers the pair within her arms. There is little surrounding furniture to explain their household or status. Light joins the faces against the darkness. The portrait's intimacy has a clear physical basis: the reduced interval between two heads, and the enclosure created by an adult holding a child.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1927.393

18 / 20

Hunting near Hartenfels Castle

Lucas Cranach the Elder

1540 · Oil, originally on wood, transferred to masonite · Cleveland Museum of Art



Hunting near Hartenfels Castle. The Cleveland Museum of Art; John L. Severance Fund. CC0 1.0. Full-frame resize and JPEG compression. · CC0 1.0

No hunter on the ground could possess this extensive view of the chase. Cranach distributes riders, dogs and deer across woods, water and open land so that separate incidents can be examined one after another. The high viewpoint makes the hunt available as an organised spectacle, with the observer enjoying a command of the scene denied to its participants.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1958.425

19 / 20

La Cervara, the Roman Campagna

Jean-Baptiste-Camille Corot

c. 1830–31 · Oil on fabric · Cleveland Museum of Art



Leonard C. Hanna Jr. Fund. The Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · CC0 1.0

Pale, uneven ground takes up the space between the sparse trees. Corot holds the view together with broad divisions of earth and sky rather than a dramatic central incident. The figures and animals establish the size of the terrain. Their modest presence also leaves the rough country available to attention on its own terms, beyond whatever errand brings them there.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1963.91

20 / 20

Morning Glory with Black

Georgia O'Keeffe

1926 · Oil on canvas · Cleveland Museum of Art



Bequest of Leonard C. Hanna Jr.. The Cleveland Museum of Art. CC0. Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · CC0 1.0

Enlarged petals leave almost no room around the flower. O'Keeffe moves the observer so close that the folds can be read as a surrounding space rather than a small botanical detail. The dark curve at the bottom interrupts the pale surfaces. That interruption matters: it gives the soft folds an edge against which their changes of light become easier to see.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1958.42

Choose a position, then compare

Try pairing a work that admits the viewer closely with one that keeps its subject at a distance. The comparison need not follow dates: Caravaggio and O'Keeffe both restrict the available space, for very different ends. This selection is not a room-by-room route. Check the museum's current object records and visiting information before planning around a particular work.

Further reading

The Practice and Science of Drawing

Harold Speed · Read free · English

Speed’s account of line, mass and composition offers practical ways to compare the crowded and sparsely arranged works here. His drawing exercises are especially relevant to the difference between Pesne’s worked sheet and more fully modelled paintings.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · Cleveland Museum of Art: Masterpieces